

Epistle to the People
Three Interesting Things
Einstein Said About God and Religion

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TL;DR: Einstein believed in a higher cosmic intelligence but rejected anthropomorphic "Church God." He argued religion evolves through three stages: fear-based tribal religion, civilization-based moral religion, and direct experiential "cosmic religious feeling." This third state—characterized by rapturous awe at natural law's harmony—he considered the strongest motivator for scientific inquiry and, if properly cultivated, a potential cure for humanity's social ills and even planetary destruction.

Abstract

This article examines Albert Einstein's nuanced perspectives on God and religion, arguing that his views resist simplistic appropriation by atheist or theist camps. Drawing on primary sources including *The World as I See It*, the Born-Einstein letters, and William Hermanns's interviews, I identify three key elements of Einstein's religious thought: (1) rejection of anthropomorphic deity in favor of a "comprehensible mystery" manifest in natural law; (2) a developmental model of religion progressing from fear-based tribalism through civilization-dependent moralism to direct "cosmic religious experience"; and (3) the assertion that such cosmic religious feeling constitutes the noblest impetus for scientific work and, if institutionally supported, could address social and ecological crises. Finally, I align Einstein's "cosmic conscience" with contemporary research on connection experiences, concluding that nurturing such experiences is essential for human and planetary survival.

Epistle to the People: Three Interesting Things Einstein Said About God and Religion

A lot of people talk about religion. A lot of people talk about God. A lot of people also talk about Albert Einstein and what he said about religion and God, and I can see why. Einstein was certainly one of the greatest minds of the 20th century and he did say some interesting things about religion and God. He's so famous and smart, people like to use the things he said to justify their beliefs, whether they be atheist, theist, pantheist, or whatever. Although I personally do not agree with everything Einstein said, his position on God and religion was nuanced. Attention, understanding, and reflection are warranted. For that reason, I'd like to share his thinking with you.

1. The Existence and Nature of God

One interesting thing Einstein said about God was that he believed in God, but not just any God. Einstein vehemently rejected belief in [Church God](https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Church_God),¹ which is God as angry, Aryan patriarch, flying around and beating bad people up. Einstein thought that "Church God" was primitive, childish rubbish. Einstein did not mince words here.

The word God is for me nothing more than the expression and product of human weakness, the Bible a collection of honorable, but still purely primitive, legends which are nevertheless pretty childish.²

Despite his rejection of Church God, Einstein did in fact believe in a higher intelligence of "such superiority that, compared with it, all the systematic thinking and acting of human beings

1 https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Church_God

2 https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Einstein_Letter_to_Eric_Gutkind

is an utterly insignificant reflection” (Einstein 2018). In a famous letter to Max Born, Einstein called this higher intelligence the “old one” and said that this intelligence is not playing dice.

Quantum mechanics is certainly imposing. But an inner voice tells me that it is not yet the real thing. The theory says a lot, but does not really bring us any closer to the secret of the 'old one'. I, at any rate, am convinced that He is not playing at dice (Einstein 1971, 91).

Einstein further said that comprehension of this intelligence sparked a particular “religious feeling,” a “rapturous amazement” so powerful it left one feeling small and utterly insignificant. In his own words:

His religious feeling takes the form of a rapturous amazement at the harmony of natural law, which reveals an intelligence of such superiority that, compared with it, all the systematic thinking and acting of human beings is an utterly insignificant reflection. **Einstein, The World as I See It (2018)**

In a discussion with sociologist William Hermanns, a personal friend, Einstein clarified:

To me, God is a mystery, but a comprehensible mystery. I have nothing but awe when I observe the laws of nature. There are not laws without a lawgiver, but how does this lawgiver look? Certainly not like a man magnified.

Hermanns, Einstein and the Poet

2. Three States of Religion

I'm sure you'll agree that Einstein's professed belief in God is interesting. Something else interesting that Einstein said, this time about religion, was that human religion went through three states. According to Einstein...

State one religion (Einstein 1930) was tribal. For Einstein, tribal religion was religion based on lack of control and fear of the natural world. In this first state, humans used magic, ritual, and sacrifice to gain control over powerful and often destructive natural forces.

With primitive man it is above all fear that evokes religious notions – fear of hunger, wild beasts, sickness, death...One's object now is to secure the favour of these beings ... to ... propitiate them or make them well disposed towards a mortal.
Einstein, Religion and Science (Einstein 1930)

Unlike state one which was based on humanity's relationship with an uncontrollable natural world, **state two** was based on humanity's relationship to civilization. In Einstein's view, inspired no doubt by Freud's (1961), state two humans reacted to the pain and angst of living in a "modern" civilization by creating a father or mother god who could protect them, nurture them, and provide them with the psychological and emotional support that society lacks. Einstein said that in state two of religion,

The desire for guidance, love, and support prompts ... the social or moral conception of God. This is the God of Providence who protects, disposes, rewards, and punishes, the God who... cherishes the life of the tribe or of the human race... the comforter in sorrow and unsatisfied longing, who preserves the souls of the dead. This is the social or moral conception of God (**Einstein 2018**)

To summarize, for Einstein, state one religion was based on humanity's relationship to the natural world while state two religion was based on humanity's relationship to civilization. In a similar vein, **state three religion** was also based on a relationship, but this time it was based on profound feelings and direct "experience" of the universe as a "single significant whole," (Einstein 2018). This state-three relationship was built not on fear or existential angst, but on direct *religious experience*. In this state, people and societies put fear, superstition, and anthropomorphic

projections behind them and embraced direct experience of the cosmos. Once people embraced direct experience, Einstein said they would develop cosmic religious feelings.

But there is a third state of religious experience which belongs to all of them, even though it is rarely found in a pure form, and which I will call cosmic religious feeling (Einstein 2018)

In this state of religion, people had cosmic religious experiences. Although I don't believe Einstein ever admitted it overtly, probably out of fear of censure, I believe he, like all of us, had at least one of these, what I would call, [connection experiences](#).

He describes feelings of rapture....

His religious feeling takes the form of a rapturous amazement at the harmony of natural law, which reveals an intelligence of such superiority that, compared with it, all the systematic thinking and acting of human beings is an utterly insignificant reflection (Einstein 2018).

...he says the experiences were profoundly humbling....

The individual feels the nothingness of human desires and aims and the sublimity and marvellous order which reveal themselves both in nature and in the world of thought.

...he notes that they cause a fundamental reevaluation of humanity's position in the cosmos...

He looks upon individual existence as a sort of prison and wants to experience the universe as a single significant whole (Einstein 2018).

FYI, these are the sorts of statements researchers have *long* recognized as aspects of "mystical" connection experience (Hood 1975). Based on his own statements, I would argue that Einstein had at least one connection experience and that this experience led him to profound cosmic

feelings. I suspect Einstein would agree. Einstein himself said that all the “profounder sort of scientific minds” have these religious feelings.

You will hardly find one among the profounder sort of scientific minds without a peculiar religious feeling of his own (Einstein 2018).

He also said that these religious feelings became the “guiding principle” of a scientist’s “life and work.” He said that this orientation was “beyond question closely akin to that which has possessed the religious geniuses of all ages.” Finally, he said that “serious scientific workers” are the only “profoundly religious people” in existence.

The Importance of Third-State Religion and Religious Feeling

Obviously, Einstein pooh-poohed neither religion as a whole nor connection experience. He thought they were significant and profound. Not only that, he thought that these experiences were incredibly important for several reasons.

He believed that these experiences gave humans strength, specifically the “strength to remain true to their purpose in spite of countless failures” (Einstein 2018).

He thought that the “cosmic religious feelings” that developed in the third state were “the strongest and noblest incitement to scientific research” (Einstein 2018).

He also suggested that an advanced third state of human religion that could encourage and support these experiences could, if it was properly purified and purged of all the accumulated nonsense, cure all our social ills, maybe even help save the planet. He didn’t mince words:

If one purges the Judaism of the Prophets and Christianity as Jesus Christ taught it of all subsequent additions, especially those of the priests, one is left with a teaching which is capable of curing all the social ills of humanity (Einstein 2018).

I would say the same of all major world religions. If you purge them of all the nonsense, there is cosmic gold inside.

I believe Einstein saw hope in connection experience. I believe he thought that cosmic religious feelings, the feelings of third-state religion, could save the planet. They would do this because they would lead to the development of what he called, but never defined, a **cosmic conscience**.

Of course, no one wants to listen to me, yet as sure as I'm sitting here *we will be destroyed unless we create a cosmic conscience*. And we have to begin to do that on an individual level, with the youth that are the politicians of tomorrow (Hermanns 1983).

That is really all I have to say on this, for now. You can believe what you want. I for one agree with Einstein on most points here. I agree God is a vast intelligence. I believe we can have direct and unitive experiences of the cosmos. I believe that these experiences change us, give us strength, and align our lives with purpose. I don't believe that only profound minds have these experiences. I believe, after Abraham Maslow, that everybody does (Sosteric 2018). I also believe, after Einstein, that if we want to save ourselves and this planet we better start nurturing these experiences and creating a cosmic conscience. If we don't, we're cooked. And that's the bottom line.

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